7x10 REPRESENTATIVE SET

Same accepted content. Same 10.9 pt body type.

Full-book pages: 61

Usable text/form width: 5.70 in

Three-way answer cell width: 1.44 in

Average prose vertical utilization: 91.0%

Low-use prose pages after removing forced part breaks: none

Printing cost tier: large-trim, black ink, fixed cost while under 110 pages

Following pages: prose, decoder, callout, extraction, comparison, questions, decision, transition.

PART I — ORIENT

1. The decision is not one number

Solar proposals invite fast comparison. One seller leads with a monthly payment. Another leads with annual production. A third displays a net price after an assumed incentive. Each headline may be mathematically defensible inside its own assumptions, yet the three headlines do not answer the same question.

The practical task is to create one common evidence set. For each proposal you need to identify at least six layers:

- commercial structure: cash purchase, loan, lease, power purchase agreement, or another arrangement;
- system definition: DC size, major equipment, quantities, and design basis;
- production model: estimated output and the assumptions behind it;
- physical and administrative scope: what work is included, excluded, allowed for, or subject to change;
- warranties and responsibility: what is covered, by whom, for how long, with which remedy and exclusions;
- transaction terms: payment schedule, cancellation, project changes, transfer, sale of the home, and the controlling documents.

These layers interact. A lower price can exclude work another quote includes. A lower monthly payment can come from a longer term or a payment change. A higher production estimate can come from a stronger design, a different weather file, a different shade model, or a more optimistic loss assumption. A 25-year headline can describe panel performance while installer workmanship lasts far less time.

The system in this book does not collapse all of that into a magic score. It makes the differences visible so that you can decide which differences matter to you.

The four evidence labels

Mark every important item with one of four labels:

- FACT — a defined value or obligation stated in a document, such as 8.2 kW DC or a quoted cash price;
- ESTIMATE — a modeled or forecast value, such as Year-1 production or projected utility escalation;

7. Ownership, transfer, and exit

Solar is attached to a home, while the financing or service arrangement may last many years. Therefore the question “What if I sell?” belongs in the first comparison, not in a future folder.

For an owned system with a loan, locate payoff and any lender security-interest terms. Ask whether assumption by a buyer is permitted and what approvals are required. For a lease or PPA, locate transfer qualification, fees, timelines, buyout options, early termination, and end-of-term removal.

Do not accept “easy transfer” without a process. Convert it into:

“Please identify the contract section governing a home sale, the documents and buyer qualifications required, all fees, the typical processing time, and the alternative if transfer is not approved.”

Also identify who owns renewable-energy certificates, tax benefits, rebates, or other attributes. Do not assume the homeowner receives them merely because the system is on the roof.

PART IV — CLAIM DECODER

8. How to read a sales claim without overreacting

Marketing language compresses. A short phrase can refer to several possible structures. The disciplined response is neither trust nor accusation. It is definition.

Use the same four-step decoder every time:

CLAIM -> WHAT IT MAY MEAN -> WHAT TO VERIFY -> QUESTION TO ASK

“Low monthly payment”

WHAT IT MAY MEAN

A long term; a temporary payment level; an expected prepayment; a larger financed principal paired with a lower stated rate; or simply a competitive fixed-payment loan.

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Use pencil for your first pass. Write proposal page numbers beside every copied value. Keep screenshots or PDFs of portal-only material. Date every revised offer. If an answer changes the price, scope, equipment, production estimate, payment schedule, or warranty, ask for a revised document rather than relying on an email sentence alone.

> THE PAUSE RULE
> If a material price, payment, ownership, production, scope, roof, electrical, warranty, cancellation, transfer, or incentive question is still unanswered, the comparison is not finished. An attractive headline is not a reason to rush an incomplete decision.

Proposal A: Commercial extraction

Write the exact stated value and its proposal page/section. Use NOT LOCATED rather than guessing.

Transaction type	
Gross cash price	
Discounts / adders	
Financed principal	
APR and term	
Payment schedule	
Expected prepayment / change	
Lease/PPA rate + escalator	
Cancellation / transfer	

Normalized price comparison

FIELD	PROPOSAL A	PROPOSAL B	PROPOSAL C
Gross cash price			
DC system watts			
Raw cash $/W			
Battery / unequal scope			
Adjusted view (labeled)			
Deposit / milestones			
Largest price contingency			
Source references			

Proposal A: written questions

Name the proposal and source. Ask for a number, definition, responsibility, or controlling document.

1. GAP / SOURCE	
QUESTION / DOCUMENT REQUEST	
2. GAP / SOURCE	
QUESTION / DOCUMENT REQUEST	
3. GAP / SOURCE	
QUESTION / DOCUMENT REQUEST	
4. GAP / SOURCE	
QUESTION / DOCUMENT REQUEST	
5. GAP / SOURCE	
QUESTION / DOCUMENT REQUEST	
6. GAP / SOURCE	
QUESTION / DOCUMENT REQUEST	

Decision record

Record the reason, not just the winner. Acknowledge remaining uncertainty.

Decision date	
Selected proposal / no decision	
Transaction type	
Main reasons	
Trade-offs accepted	
Material facts relied on	
Documents controlling decision	
Remaining uncertainty	
Independent advice obtained	
Next action / deadline	

This record documents a process; it does not guarantee performance, savings, service, or legal outcome.

Warranty and service fields

Capture warranty category, covered component or work, term, start date, responsible party, remedy, labor, shipping, diagnosis, removal and reinstallation, roof penetrations, transfer, registration requirements, exclusions, and service-response commitment if any.

Do not merge manufacturer and installer obligations. If a module maker supplies a replacement part but the installer does not cover labor, "warranty coverage" can still leave a homeowner with a bill.

Missing is a productive answer

The extraction sheet is successful when it reveals uncertainty early. A blank field is not a personal failure. It is a generated question. Write "not located" rather than guessing.

> EXTRACTION STANDARD
> Copy first, interpret second. Preserve units. Preserve whether a price is cash, financed, gross, or "net." Preserve whether capacity is DC or AC. Preserve whether production is Year 1, average annual, or lifetime. Preserve whether a payment is initial, fixed, or conditional.

PART III — NORMALIZE PRICE AND FINANCING

5. Cash price is the common anchor

For purchase proposals, ask every installer for the cash price of the same defined scope. That number gives you a common commercial anchor even if you intend to finance.

Cash price does not mean "best price," and cost per watt does not make scope differences disappear. It simply prevents a monthly-payment headline from replacing the underlying installation price.

Cash cost per watt

Formula:

CASH COST PER WATT = CASH PRICE / (DC SYSTEM SIZE IN kW x 1,000)

8x10 REPRESENTATIVE SET

Same accepted content. Same 10.9 pt body type.

Full-book pages: 57

Usable text/form width: 6.70 in

Three-way answer cell width: 1.75 in

Average prose vertical utilization: 91.9%

Low-use prose pages after removing forced part breaks: none

Printing cost tier: large-trim, black ink, fixed cost while under 110 pages

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- MISSING — a material field you cannot locate or calculate from the documents supplied.

A fact can still be incomplete. A contract may state a price without explaining change-order exposure. An estimate can be useful without being guaranteed. A claim is not automatically false. Missing information is not proof of an unfavorable answer; it is a reason to ask.

The source-reference habit

Never copy a value without noting where it came from. Use a short reference such as “Proposal A, p. 6, Cash Option” or “Loan disclosure, p. 2.” This prevents a common failure: remembering the salesperson's explanation while losing the document that supposedly supports it.

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“Low monthly payment”

WHAT IT MAY MEAN

A long term; a temporary payment level; an expected prepayment; a larger financed principal paired with a lower stated rate; or simply a competitive fixed-payment loan.

WHAT TO VERIFY

Cash price for identical scope; financed principal; APR; term; every payment level and date; fees; expected prepayment; re-amortization; balloon payment; official total of payments; prepayment terms.

QUESTION TO ASK

“Please provide the lender disclosure showing principal, APR, all payment amounts and dates, total of payments, fees, and every event that changes the required payment.”

“No money down”

WHAT IT MAY MEAN

No payment at installation. A loan, lease, PPA, lien, long-term payment obligation, or cancellation exposure may still begin.

WHAT TO VERIFY

Transaction type; ownership; contract length; principal or payment rate; escalation; security interest; cancellation; transfer; payoff; end-of-term obligations.

QUESTION TO ASK

“What financial or contractual obligation begins when I sign, and what must be paid, transferred, purchased, or removed if I sell the home or end the agreement?”

How this book earns its place next to your proposals

A spreadsheet can compare numbers after you know which numbers belong together. A calculator can estimate production after you choose assumptions. A marketplace can make offers from participating sellers look more uniform. None of those tools necessarily teaches you how to take three differently structured proposals, locate their controlling facts, expose hidden assumptions, and turn each unresolved gap into a written question.

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PART I — ORIENT

1. The decision is not one number

Solar proposals invite fast comparison. One seller leads with a monthly payment. Another leads with annual production. A third displays a net price after an assumed incentive. Each headline may be mathematically defensible inside its own assumptions, yet the three headlines do not answer the same question.

The practical task is to create one common evidence set. For each proposal you need to identify at least six layers:

Proposal A: Commercial extraction

Write the exact stated value and its proposal page/section. Use NOT LOCATED rather than guessing.

Transaction type	
Gross cash price	
Discounts / adders	
Financed principal	
APR and term	
Payment schedule	
Expected prepayment / change	
Lease/PPA rate + escalator	
Cancellation / transfer	

Normalized price comparison

FIELD	PROPOSAL A	PROPOSAL B	PROPOSAL C
Gross cash price			
DC system watts			
Raw cash $/W			
Battery / unequal scope			
Adjusted view (labeled)			
Deposit / milestones			
Largest price contingency			
Source references			

Proposal A: written questions

Name the proposal and source. Ask for a number, definition, responsibility, or controlling document.

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QUESTION / DOCUMENT REQUEST	
2. GAP / SOURCE	
QUESTION / DOCUMENT REQUEST	
3. GAP / SOURCE	
QUESTION / DOCUMENT REQUEST	
4. GAP / SOURCE	
QUESTION / DOCUMENT REQUEST	
5. GAP / SOURCE	
QUESTION / DOCUMENT REQUEST	
6. GAP / SOURCE	
QUESTION / DOCUMENT REQUEST	

Decision record

Record the reason, not just the winner. Acknowledge remaining uncertainty.

Decision date	
Selected proposal / no decision	
Transaction type	
Main reasons	
Trade-offs accepted	
Material facts relied on	
Documents controlling decision	
Remaining uncertainty	
Independent advice obtained	
Next action / deadline	

This record documents a process; it does not guarantee performance, savings, service, or legal outcome.

Do not merge manufacturer and installer obligations. If a module maker supplies a replacement part but the installer does not cover labor, “warranty coverage” can still leave a homeowner with a bill.

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PART III — NORMALIZE PRICE AND FINANCING

5. Cash price is the common anchor

For purchase proposals, ask every installer for the cash price of the same defined scope. That number gives you a common commercial anchor even if you intend to finance.

Cash price does not mean “best price,” and cost per watt does not make scope differences disappear. It simply prevents a monthly-payment headline from replacing the underlying installation price.

Cash cost per watt

Formula:

CASH COST PER WATT = CASH PRICE / (DC SYSTEM SIZE IN kW x 1,000)

For the synthetic proposal:

$24,600 / (8.2 x 1,000) = $3.00 per watt.

DOE consumer guidance describes this normalization method when comparing installer quotes. Use it as a starting point, not a ranking. It becomes misleading when proposals bundle materially different items such as batteries, roofing, service upgrades, trenching, or unusually broad warranties.

Before comparing, annotate unequal scope. If one quote includes a $2,000 electrical allowance, you may show both the proposal's raw cost per watt and an adjusted comparison

8.5x11 REPRESENTATIVE SET

Same accepted content. Same 10.9 pt body type.

Full-book pages: 54

Usable text/form width: 7.20 in

Three-way answer cell width: 1.92 in

Average prose vertical utilization: 91.5%

Low-use prose pages after removing forced part breaks: none

Printing cost tier: large-trim, black ink, fixed cost while under 110 pages

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When two documents conflict, do not choose the more favorable one. Record the conflict and ask which term will control. If a proposal says “fixed payment” and the lender schedule shows two payment levels, the discrepancy is itself a decision fact.

> QUICK TEST
> Can another adult pick up your packet and find the source for the cash price, financed principal, production estimate, major exclusions, and warranty terms in under five minutes? If not, your extraction is not yet auditable.

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WHAT IT MAY MEAN

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“Please provide the lender disclosure showing principal, APR, all payment amounts and dates, total of payments, fees, and every event that changes the required payment.”

“No money down”

WHAT IT MAY MEAN

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WHAT TO VERIFY

Transaction type; ownership; contract length; principal or payment rate; escalation; security interest; cancellation; transfer; payoff; end-of-term obligations.

QUESTION TO ASK

“What financial or contractual obligation begins when I sign, and what must be paid, transferred, purchased, or removed if I sell the home or end the agreement?”

“25-year warranty”

WHAT IT MAY MEAN

A module performance warranty; module product warranty; inverter warranty; installer workmanship warranty; roof-penetration warranty; labor coverage; or several separate terms with different providers.

WHAT TO VERIFY

Covered item; triggering failure; term; start date; exclusions; claim procedure; remedy; parts; diagnosis; shipping; labor; removal and reinstallation; responsible party; transfer and registration.

QUESTION TO ASK

“Please separate every warranty by covered item, term, exclusions, remedy, labor and shipping coverage, and the company responsible for honoring it.”

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Documents controlling decision	
Remaining uncertainty	
Independent advice obtained	
Next action / deadline	

This record documents a process; it does not guarantee performance, savings, service, or legal outcome.

Scope fields

Capture roof inspection, roof repair, removal and reinstallation, structural work, main-panel or service upgrade, trenching, conduit routing, attic work, permits, inspections, interconnection, utility fees, homeowner-association submissions, monitoring setup, commissioning, cleanup, and responsibility for failed inspections or redesign.

The purpose is not to demand that every item be included. It is to make price exposure visible.

Warranty and service fields

Capture warranty category, covered component or work, term, start date, responsible party, remedy, labor, shipping, diagnosis, removal and reinstallation, roof penetrations, transfer, registration requirements, exclusions, and service-response commitment if any.

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